

MORE
BELUGAS
DIE AT
SHEDD

Necropsies underway after
third whale death in two weeks.
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confesses to
taking videos
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in the nude

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Chicago Tribune



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Thanks to warmer, wetter summer, mosquitoes and other insects are swarming Chicagoland, especially around standing water and the lakefront beaches



Swat on the trails

By Allison Kiehl | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

In the parks, at the lakefront and beyond, swarms of mosquitoes, flies and other insects are chasing away Chicagoans trying to enjoy the last breaths of summer. More so than in previous years, insects have been pervasive — and it's no coincidence why.

Bugs, mosquitoes in particular, thrive and breed in hot, wet conditions, which is exactly the climate that Chicagoland has had this summer. According to National Weather Service data, 2026 marked the 17th-wettest summer since 1871.

Uptown residents Agnieszka Romek and her husband, Andrezej, always come to the same spot at Montrose Beach: a large rock toward the back of the beach that they sit on together, slightly tucked away into the brush. Their view ahead is the expansive sandy beach with Lake Michigan beyond.

On Thursday afternoon, their spot was also inhabited by small black and striped insects flying about the vegetation that the couple was forced to swat away. When the bugs landed on their skin, it left a faint stinging sensation. Romek said she had never seen this many bugs at the beach before.

"We are here every week," Romek said. "It was never like this."

As Labor Day approaches, the pesky pests, including cicadas that seem to be extra loud

Karen Franklin greets a Labrador retriever at Montrose Beach in Chicago's Uptown neighborhood on Thursday. Franklin said she saw an army of flies at the dog beach on Tuesday.

ARTHUR MAIORELLA/
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

this year, threaten to upend backyard barbecues and lakefront beach parties with their buzzing invasions.

The heavy rains Chicago saw this summer could have led to a higher presence of swarming insects, as flies and mosquitoes both prefer to breed near pools of still water, according to Chris Dietrich, a University of Illinois entomologist.

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CHICAGO BUDGET

Mayor
reveals
\$882M
deficit

Johnson puts blame on past mismanagement, refuses to reject property tax increase

By Alice Yin and A.D. Quig
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Mayor Brandon Johnson's administration on Thursday unveiled a projected \$882.4 million hole in the 2027 budget, officially starting the clock for another slugfest with aldermen over how to close the gap before the end of this year.

The mayor cast the predicament as all too predictable in a briefing with reporters in which he blamed historic fiscal mismanagement as well as his council opponents who stymied his progressive agenda.

"As we prepare to put forward our 2027 budget proposal in the coming weeks, we will learn from the lessons of 2026," Johnson said. "My administration's values have not changed. We will not balance this budget on the backs of working people."

Johnson refused to outright reject hiking property taxes or laying off city workers in an election year to deal with the still-colossal shortfall, though he said he hopes to avoid either of those politically fraught options. He did commit to making the \$364 million "advance" pension payment in 2027 — a continuation of a policy from Mayor Lori Lightfoot to help keep the city's retiree funds from going underwater.

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Trump takes
another swing
at campus DEI

Treasury rule would strip tax exemption for colleges

By Collin Binkley
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — The Trump administration is proposing a new rule that would strip private schools and colleges of their tax-exempt status if they provide targeted help to students based on their race, a significant escalation in the White House's campaign to eradicate diversity programs directed at Black, Hispanic and other minority students.

The Treasury Department proposed the change Thursday in a new regulation that, if made final, would kick in after May 2027. The rule is broadly aimed at ending any policies or programs that help students because of their race, and it specifically says such benefits in admissions, scholarships and facilities "would be incompatible" with the rule.

It's the latest attempt by the Trump administration to pressure schools and colleges to weed out diversity, equity and inclusion policies that had become

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Cardinal Cupich,
nuns sue Illinois
to block medical
aid-in-dying law

By Jeremy Gorner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Chicago's Catholic archbishop, two orders of Catholic nuns and other plaintiffs filed a federal lawsuit Thursday to block the state from enforcing a controversial Illinois law set to take effect next week that would let doctors prescribe medication to help terminally ill patients end their lives.

It's the latest legal challenge to Illinois' End-of-Life Options for Terminally Ill Patients Act, which Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker signed into law in December after the Catholic Church emerged as one of its most vocal opponents during debate in Springfield. In June, separate suits were filed on the same day seeking to halt medical-aid-in-dying laws in Illinois and New York.

The Illinois law lets a terminally ill patient — someone given up to six months to live by a doctor — request and ingest



Cardinal Blase Cupich helps to lead a procession around Our Lady of Mount Carmel Parish in Melrose Park following an outdoor Ash Wednesday Mass on Feb. 18. CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

life-ending prescription medication. Its passage and the governor's signature capped a yearslong debate at the state Capitol over whether Illinois would allow the practice.

Thursday's lawsuit, filed a little more than a week before the law is expected to take effect on Sept. 12, names Cardinal Blase Cupich, the Carmelite Sisters for the

Aged and Infirm, the Little Sisters of the Poor Chicago Province and a downstate pharmacist among its plaintiffs. It names three state officials as defendants: Sameer Vohra, director of the Illinois Department of Public Health; Mario Treto Jr., secretary

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